

CHAPTER 1

Money Lessons I Learned from My Mother

In the same way that our relationship to food is shaped by lessons learned during childhood, so, too, is our relationship with money. It is often our parents, for better or for worse, who teach us our first money lessons. My mother, Georgette, was a master with money. She was born in Montreal to parents of Lebanese descent. And while she didn't have a fancy business degree, she was thrust into the family clothing business at a very young age, after the sudden death of her father. In the Lebanese culture, businesses are usually passed down to the boys, but her brother, Norman, was too young to take over. So in the beginning, it was up to my mother and her sister to keep the business running until Norman was old enough to take over. Turns out, my mom was a natural at balancing the books. She met my father, Terry, through the family business. He was a charismatic guy and one of the company's most talented salesmen—until his personal problems meant he lost every penny he earned.

Many marriages crash against the unforgiving shores of bad money management, and too often children bear the brunt of their parents' financial decisions. My parents shielded my brother, Shane, and me from the worst of their marital woes, but my mother's marriage to my father broke down largely over money matters. He was good to Shane and me, but he was a fun-loving Irishman who liked to buy rounds at the bar and gamble with his friends.

I was six years old when my mother was granted sole custody of Shane and me. She got remarried, to a man named George Kanawaty,